

medal will place her among the best at the pinnacle of Indian sports history. She was the toast of the country after her Tokyo win, but she and her coach knew from experience just how fleeting all that adulation can be.

Less than a year ago, after competing in the 49kg category at the Asian Games in Hangzhou, Mirabai returned to India in a wheelchair. She had been dealing with pain in her right hip during warm-ups but had still opted to compete. It was clear she was nowhere near her best. After a snatch lift opener of 83kg, followed by two failed attempts, she registered a 108kg opener in the clean and jerk section. At that point, her total read 191kg, which placed her fourth behind Thailand's Thanyathon Sukcharoen, who had lifted 199kg.

Planning to overtake her, Mirabai loaded 117kg on the bar for another clean and jerk attempt. After her first lift failed, she went for it once again. As she spread her palms around the bar and squatted, lifting it onto her collarbones, she crumbled, falling down and lying on her side, the bar dropping in front of her. The broadcast cut to her competitors backstage, but behind them, one could see Mirabai being carried away by one of India's coaching staff.

It was one of the lowest moments in her career. Sharma says, "If we have to compare it to anything, I think it would have to be what happened at the 2016 Rio Olympics." That's when Mirabai, despite being one of the medal favourites, did not even post a total after failing all her lifts in the clean and jerk category. "That time we just finished without a medal; the scars were only in our mind. This time (Asian Games), Mira had an injury as well," says Sharma.

When she arrived at New Delhi airport, Mirabai was still in a wheelchair. Travelling along with her was the Indian shooting contingent, buoyed by a record medal haul. As the media surrounded them, Sharma wheeled her away to catch another flight to Mumbai, where she would meet Dr. Dinshaw Pardiwala, an

orthopaedic surgeon specialised in sports injuries.

Before that fateful lift, Sharma remembers asking Mirabai whether she should withdraw from the competition. For Mirabai, though, the answer was obvious. She'd won medals in every other competition she had taken part in — gold at the 2017 World Championships, silver in the Tokyo Olympics, gold at the Commonwealth Games, and a bronze at the 2020 Asian Championships. The only medal



WHILE THEY COULDN'T DIAGNOSE THE ISSUE, MIRABAI WAS ADVISED REST AND TO REHABILITATE HER HIP UNTIL AT LEAST THE END OF THE YEAR



missing in her collection was the Asian Games; she'd missed out once before at the 2018 edition in Jakarta, where she had to withdraw because of a back injury.

"My dream was to win a medal in the Asian Games. I really wanted it. When I started my career, my coach told me that it is the biggest event in the sport because the best female weightlifters are all from Asia. After I got injured, I wondered if perhaps it was not my destiny to win this medal. I kept wondering — why did this happen? Of all competitions, why did it have to happen at the Asian Games?"

Sharma says he had similar questions as well. "We were in perfect shape. We had been training in the USA for several weeks, working with Aaron Horschig (a strength and conditioning expert). I was so confident that she would get a medal in Hangzhou," he recalls.

Now, though, with less than a year to go for the Paris Olympics, there wasn't even any assurance whether Mirabai would be able to compete again. "When I returned to India, I

couldn't even walk. There was so much pain inside my right hip that I couldn't put any weight on my foot. I had to be carried down the stairs by my coach. There was a lot of pain because it was inside my joint," she says.

Once the pain started to subside in a few days, Mirabai found some hope. "I honestly thought her career was finished when we went and met Dr. Pardiwala. She couldn't even put any weight on her right foot in Hangzhou, and she wasn't even able to walk when she first came to Mumbai. Within a couple of days, though, she was able to put weight on her foot. Once she started walking, we knew it wasn't nearly as

